

ARTISTIC EXPRESSION

Romantics and renegades

During the 1700s and into the 1800s—an age of revolution and Romanticism—supernatural and occult ideas inspired major creative works. Romanticism celebrated an individual's emotions and expression; it often broke free of accepted rules and valued intuition and transcendence (experience beyond the normal, physical level). The artistic outpouring of the Romantic era was fueled by political revolutions that ousted old orders across the world, from France to North America, and was a reaction against the rational Enlightenment.

Goya's mysterious witches

Spanish artist Goya had a deep interest in witches and the supernatural. He used the imagery of dark fantasy to explore social and political realism,

◀ Occult allegory

Here, Goya's witches wear hats that may echo headgear worn by those prosecuted during the Spanish Inquisition, while the man below is making a hand gesture to ward off the evil eye.



producing some compelling but sinister paintings. The intriguing *Witches' Flight* (c. 1798, left) shows three airborne witches carrying a fourth, splayed person. The work's meaning is contested: it could be an anti-witchcraft statement or a criticism of the religious establishment.

Nature and the demonic

Literature and music also explored otherworldly themes. American poet-philosophers Ralph Waldo Emerson and Henry David Thoreau created a Transcendental school of writing that promoted

Romantic ideals of intuition, seeing God in nature, and personal liberty. The supernatural was featured by various British Romantic poets, led by William Wordsworth and Samuel Taylor Coleridge, who explored the divine magic of nature in works such as their joint *Lyrical Ballads*.

In contrast to admiring the magic of nature, American Dark Romantics, especially Edgar Allan Poe, created literary works that combined necromancy (communicating with the dead), the occult, metempsychosis (the transmigration of souls), ceremonial magic, and mesmerism (see pp.210–213). Two of Poe's short stories that encapsulated such themes were "Morella," a morbid four-page tale of marriage, Gothic horror, and mysticism, and "Ligeia," which included a magic circle and opium-induced visions of a corpse coming back to life.

In the world of opera, von Weber's work *Der Freischütz* is famed for its unsettling supernaturalism. It features a battle between good and evil involving strange spirits, a Devil's pact, and magic bullets.

◀ Supernatural messages of doom

In Edgar Allan Poe's poem "The Raven," illustrated here by Gustave Doré, a man yearning to meet his lost love in heaven has all hope dashed by a talking raven messenger.



▲ Spirit landscape

This print shows an early set for the disturbing Wolf's Glen scene in German Romantic Carl Maria von Weber's opera *Der Freischütz* (1821). The set's landscape is alive with spirits and odd creatures.